

KIAN RAVAEI

**THE FOUR
SEASONS OF
HAMADAN**

for solo violin

ÆI edition

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(2025)

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*Commissioned by Bridge to Everywhere
with generous support from the New Music USA Creator Fund.*

PROGRAM NOTE

In December 2022, Annie Kahane and I set out to create a new music and dance work in which we would each learn from the other's cultural heritage. I would immerse myself in Jewish music, Annie would study Persian dance, and we would then draw from our experiences to create a truly bicultural work of art. Our piece would be structured around the idea of ancient seasonal rituals, reminding us of our shared connection to the earth and its miraculous ways of marking time.

This is how *The Four Seasons of Hamadan* started. The title refers to the city of Hamadan in present-day Iran, where it is believed that the Old Testament heroine Esther and her husband Mordecai are buried. Because of its location and history, Hamadan represents a meeting point between Persian and Jewish culture, an apt metaphor for my collaboration with Annie.

I spent a year taking lessons in Jewish music and klezmer composition with Sherry Mayrent, once associate director of the legendary KlezKamp—an annual culture festival responsible for the promulgation of Yiddish art in the United States. Sherry is not only one of the most generous people I know, but also one of the leading figures in Jewish music preservation. The Mayrent Institute for Yiddish Culture at the University of Wisconsin-Madison, an outgrowth of her preservation work, houses over 9,000 Yiddish recordings, each one painstakingly catalogued from her personal collection. In our lessons together, she critiqued dozens of my original klezmer tunes (having written hundreds herself) and introduced me to a wide range of Jewish musical traditions, from Yiddish vaudeville to cantorial singing.

While studying Jewish music with Sherry, I also began learning to play the setār, a Persian long-necked lute. My teacher Fariborz Azizi insisted that the only way to further my understanding of Iranian classical music was to learn a traditional instrument; so he repaired my setār, a dust-worn instrument my father had bought in Iran years ago, and gifted me a plectrum made of iron and leather. I studied from the method book of the great setār player Hossein Alizadeh, who was Fariborz's teacher, and I composed a paraphrase of Alizadeh's *Chāhārmezrābe Chāhārgāh* which is included in the second movement of this piece. Playing the setār gave me an embodied understanding of countless nuances of Iranian classical music, which years of theoretical study never did.

The first movement pays homage to Nowruz, the Persian New Year occurring on the Spring solstice, and Purim, the Springtime celebration of Jewish deliverance as recounted in the Book of Esther. Alternating between the Persian mode Darāmade Māhur and the Jewish mode Hashem Molokh, the improvisatory melody is accompanied by a musical device common to both traditions: the drone. Early klezmer recordings feature melodies played over a cimbalom intoning a single note, while Iranian classical compositions often use the drone note to fill in rhythmic gaps. Drones also bring to mind the pastorate genre of Western classical music, characterized by sustained background notes thought to evoke the verdant countryside.

Zarbi, the Persian word for a rhythmic composition, encapsulates the character of the second movement, which shines a light on the energetic rhythms of Jewish and Persian music. In Jewish traditions, rhythmic pieces are for dancing, often as part of wedding festivities, while the zarbis of Persian classical music evoke the idea of dance but primarily function as art music. The specific forms I incorporate include: the freylikh, a jaunty klezmer dance in double time; the hora, another klezmer dance, but in triple time, and with an idiosyncratic lilt on beat 3; and the chāhārmezrāb, a fast, etude-like composition typically played on the Persian tār or setār, both traditional plucked string instruments. Vivaldi's effervescent depiction of summer storms from his *Four Seasons* came to mind as I contemplated the spirit of Shuavot and Tirgan, both celebratory summer festivals.

While writing the third movement, I had front of mind something that Fariborz told me in one of our lessons, as he tried to get me to play with more poetry and elegance: "All Persian art—especially music—strives to match the greatness of Persian literature." In a similar vein, Sherry emphasized the inextricable link between Jewish linguistic and musical practice, showing how melodies draw from the cadences of Yiddish and Hebrew language. Therefore, this movement aims to demonstrate how Persian and Jewish vocal traditions—specifically Persian classical singing and Jewish cantorial singing—translate into the technical idioms of kamāncheh and klezmer fiddle playing. I composed original melodies to the Hebrew prayer Avinu Malkeinu ("Our Father, Our King") and to the Persian poet Hafiz's Ghazal No. 1, instructing the violinist to sing the lyrics internally, letting it guide their performance. It happens that vocal practice in both Persian and Jewish music centers improvisation, giving this movement a feeling of melodic abundance, which seems fitting to commemorate the harvest festivals of Mehregan and Sukkot.

The winter rituals of Yalda and Hanukkah complete the cycle, and it is both the sense of completion and cyclicity that inspired me to end with a chaconne. Like Bach’s beloved D Minor Chaconne, the violin weaves a repeating pattern of harmonies, but while doing so evokes myriad styles of Persian and Jewish music. For example, the principal theme which begins the movement mixes a Jewish *terkisher* with a French overture (a nod to Bach), and is shortly followed by a Persian *tasnif*, or ballad. In a way, this final movement is a compact summation of the transcultural polystylism that the work as a whole sets out to achieve. Just as winter turns to spring and the seasons begin anew, the piece ends on the same drone note from the beginning.

Annie and I hope that this work may serve as an example of empathy and cultural understanding between individuals with different backgrounds and identities. In the face of ongoing political hostilities between Iran and Israel, who have been in a proxy war for over four decades, our aim is to demonstrate the potential for people to unite around rituals, seasons, and cultural commonalities. We extend our gratitude to New Music USA for supporting our collaboration through the New Music Creator Fund, to Bridge to Everywhere and the Music Department at Mount Saint Mary’s University for helping us workshop the piece, and most of all, to our teachers, who graciously passed on their knowledge so that we might keep these art forms alive.

—Kian Ravaei

PERFORMANCE NOTES

Blink Symbol

This score uses a “Blink” symbol (see figure below) to indicate a type of ornamentation where a note is approached with a rapid grace note. The grace note should not be accented. The main note should also be unaccented; it should be thought of as a quick flick of the finger. This type of ornamentation is called an *eshare* in Iranian classical music.



is the same as

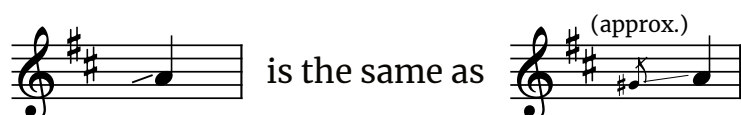


Quasi Vibrato Trill

All trills throughout this piece should be played as “quasi vibrato” trills, in which the vibrato motion of the lower finger causes the upper finger to gently but rapidly rock up and down. Klezmer fiddle player Alicia Svigals demonstrates the technique in [this video](https://youtu.be/TBwnE8F_vYs) (youtu.be/TBwnE8F_vYs).

Scoop

A scoop (see figure below) is a quick upward slide into a note, starting approximately a semitone below.



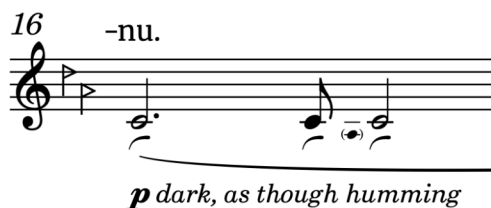
Quasi Krekht

The figure below may be played in the manner of a *kekht*, a Jewish vocal ornament that imitates sobbing. Unlike classical grace notes, *kekhts* are tied to the preceding note. As Alicia Svigals demonstrates in [this video](https://youtu.be/Wyz0Dg-_ssU) (youtu.be/Wyz0Dg-_ssU), the bow should be tugged and immediately halted at the moment the upper grace note is stopped.



Koron

The triangular flag-shaped accidental indicates a *koron*, an Iranian microtone which is approximately a quarter-tone flat in relation to 12-tone equal temperament.



duration ca. 23'

THE FOUR SEASONS OF HAMADAN

for solo violin

Kian Ravaei

(2025)

to Annie Kahane

I. Spring: Nowruz & Purim

Vibrant ♩ = ca. 40 (improvisatory, flexible rhythm)

(repeat gesture ad lib., gradually speeding up;
exact number of repetitions is not important)

quasi vibrato
trill (sempre)*

non vib.

pp

*

mf *pp*

(an improvisation in the Persian mode Darāmade Māhur)
(bow freely, add slurs ad lib.)

3

mf *pp*

poco vib. when it feels right
(scoop)*

4

p *quasi krekht** *mf* *pp*

(now in the Jewish mode Hashem Molokh)

5

p *mf* *f* *mf*

[5]

non vib.

pp *mf* *pp* *p*

(back to Darāmade Māhur)

*) See performance notes.

[6]

mf *p* *mf* *pp* *p*

[7]

mf *f* *mf* *f* *pp*

8

poco vib. ad lib.

p *mf* *f*

(back to Hashem Molokh)

[8]

mf *f* *mf* *pp*

9

p *f* *f*

[9]

p *f* *f*

(gradually slow down trill)

10

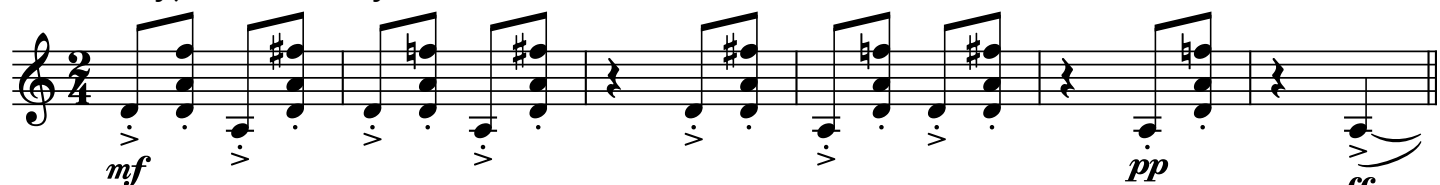
mf *p* *pp*

espr.

to Fariborz Azizi

II. Summer: Tirgan & Shavuot

Jaunty, with a heavy lilt ♩ = 72

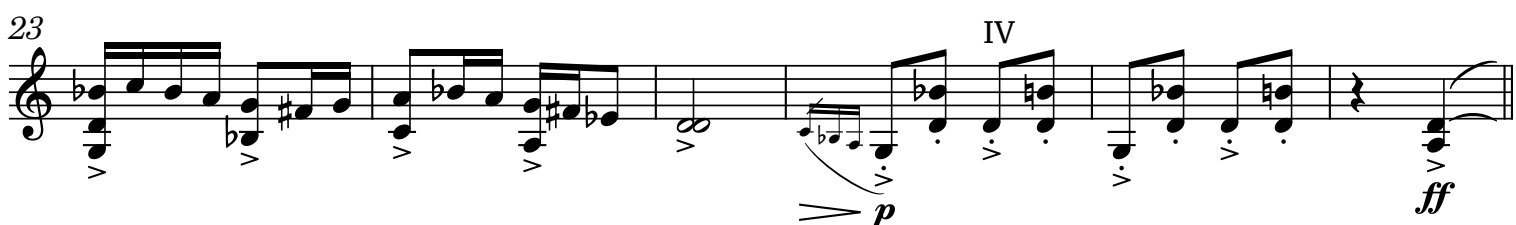


Senza misura, ad lib.



a tempo

(a Freylikh in the Freygish mode)



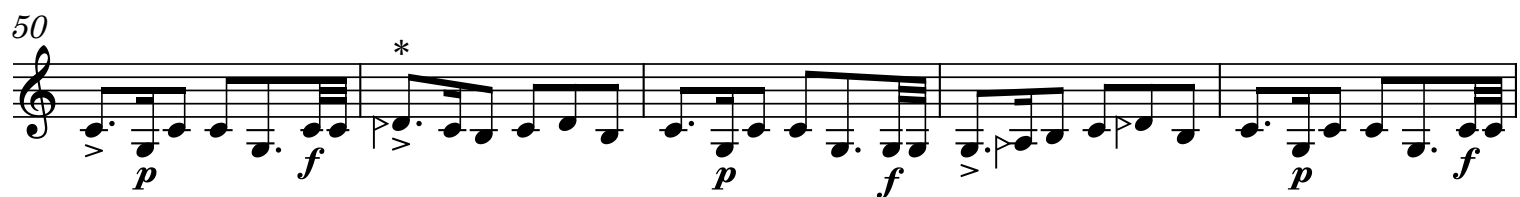
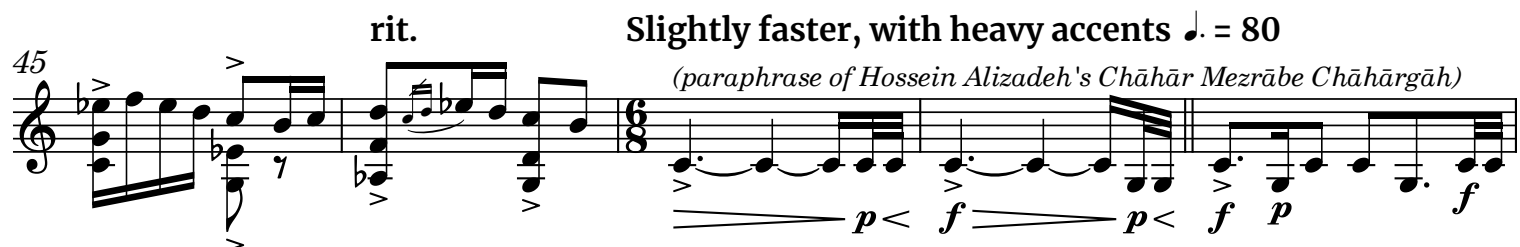
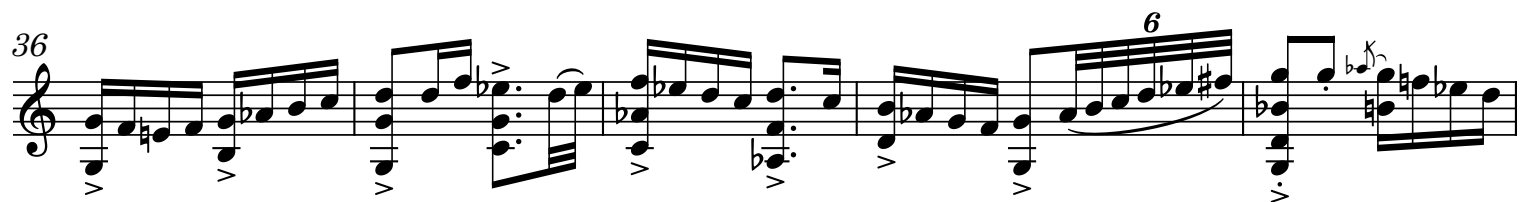
(slow gliss. while trilling)

Senza misura, ad lib.

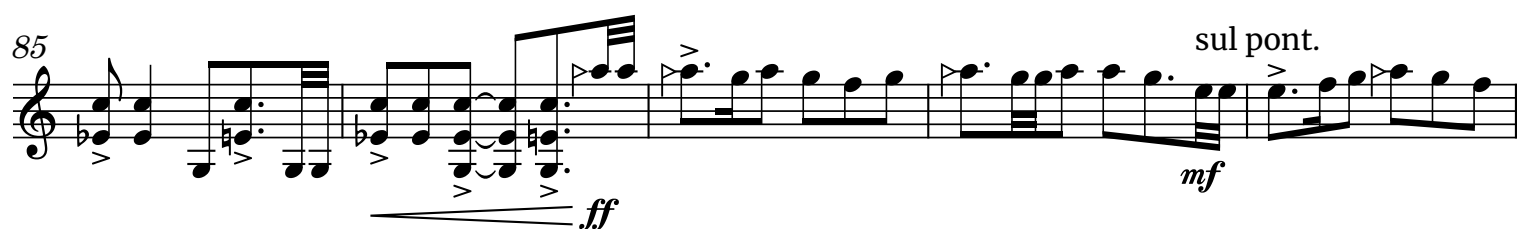


a tempo

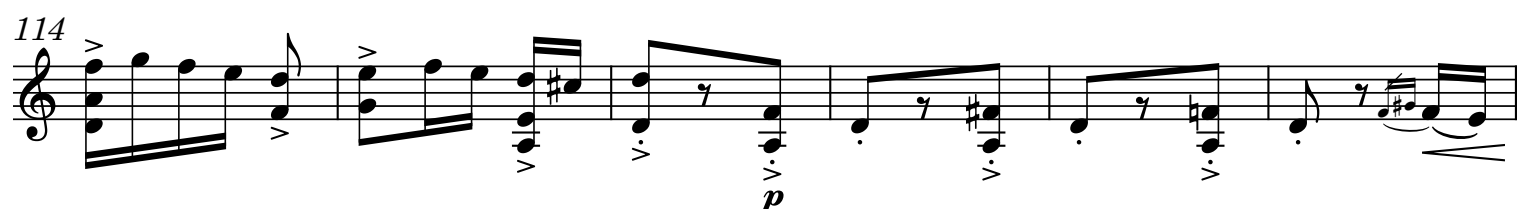




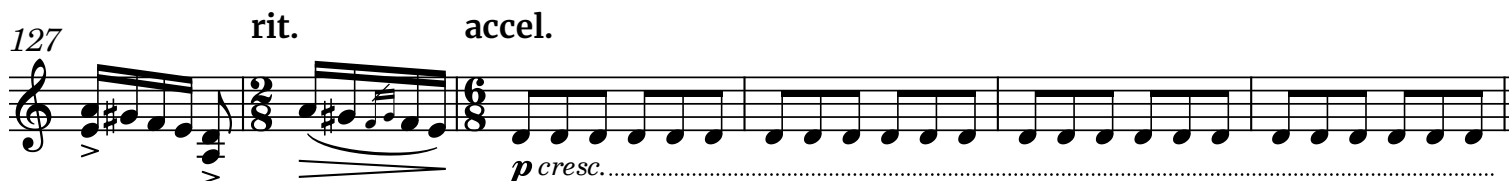
*) See performance notes.



Hora, with a characteristic lilt on beat 3 ♩ = 112



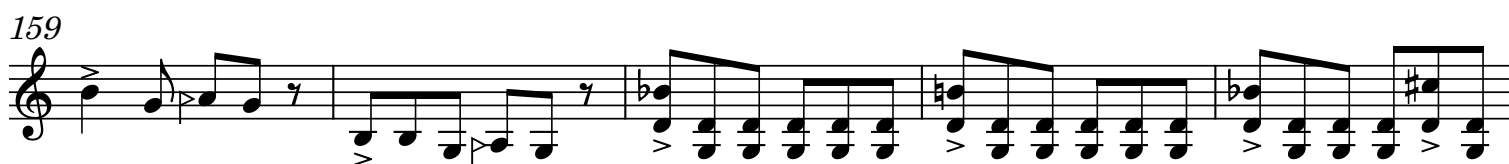
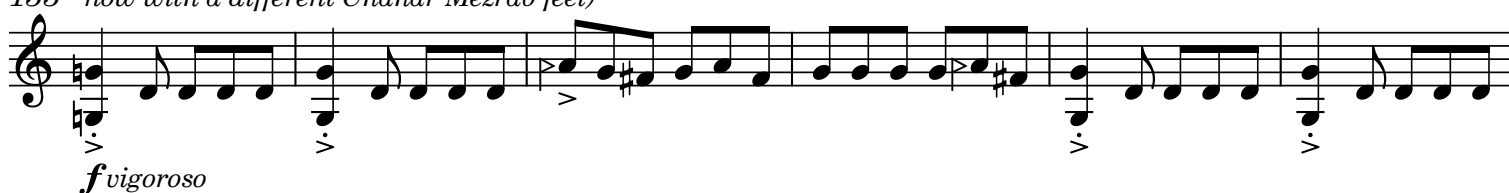
120 (the same melody in the Mishebeyrek mode)



Presto, ben misurato ♩. = 152

(the same melody from before,

133 now with a different Chāhār Mezrāb feel)



164 **accel.**

Prestissimo ♩ = ♩ = 152

169 (*the Freylikh from before, but now twice as fast*)

f

174

179

184

189

Senza misura, ad lib. (♩ = ca. 72)

194

sf **sf** **sf** **tr**

[195] **Tempo I** ♩ = 72

mf **p** **pp**

to Sherry Mayrent

III. Autumn: Mehregan & Sukkot

In the manner of a Jewish cantor ♩ = ca. 72 (improvisatory, flexible rhythm)

(Our Father, Our King...)

(...Our Father, Our King...)

*A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu,

A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu,



(...Our Father, Our King.)

A - vi - - nu mal - kei - - - - -



(Our Father, Our King,...)

(...hear our voices.)

- - nu.

A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu, sh' - ma kol - lei - nu.



(Our Father, Our King,...)

(...we have sinned in Your presence.)

A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu,

kha - ta - nu l' - fa - ne - kha.



(Our Father, Our King,...)

(...have compassion on us and our children.)

A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu,

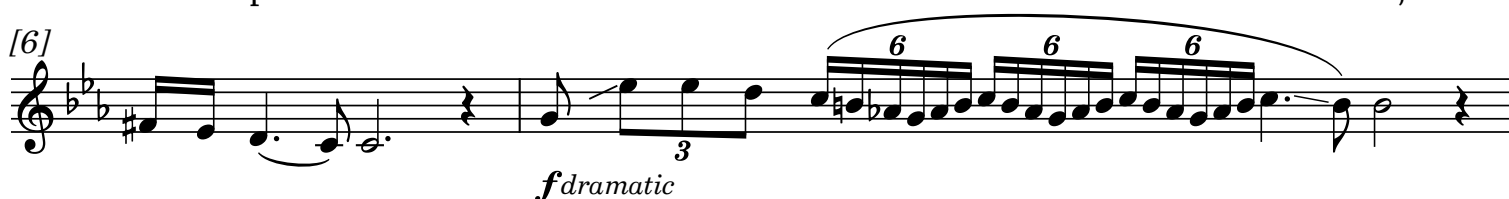
kha - mol a - lei - nu v' - al o - la - lei - nu



v' - ta - pei - nu.

(Our Father, Our King,...)

A - vi - nu mal - kei - - - - - nu,



*) The words are not to be sung aloud, but sung internally to inspire the musical interpretation.

(...rid us of disease, war, and hunger.)

ka - leh de - ver v' - he - rev v' - raav mei - a - lei - - - nu.



(Our Father, Our King,...)

(...rid us of every oppressor and adversary.)

A - vi-nu mal - kei - nu, ka - leh khol tzar u - mas - tin mei - a - lei-nu.



(Our Father, Our King,...)

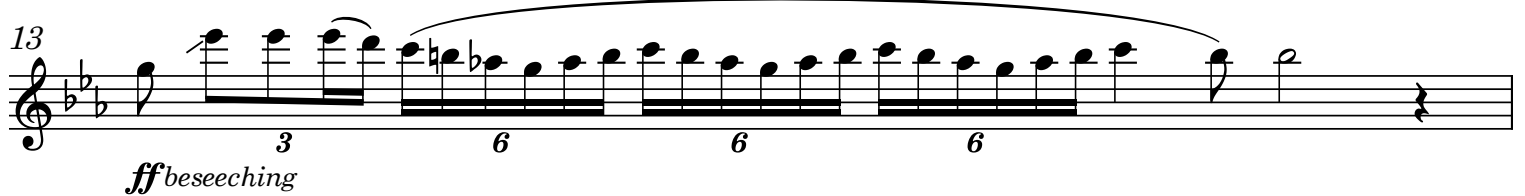
(...inscribe us for good in the Book of Life.)

A - vi - nu mal - kei - nu, kot vei - nu b' - se - fer kha - yim to - vim.



(Our Father, Our King,...)

A - vi - nu mal - kei - - - - - nu,



(...inscribe us for good in the Book of Life.)

(Our Father, Our King.)

kha - desh a - lei - nu sha - nah to - vah.

A - vi - nu mal - kei -



In the manner of a Persian classical singer ♩ = ca. 72 (improvisatory, flexible rhythm)

non vib. sempre

(Tahrir—wordless singing.)

(poco a poco

al wide vib.)



*) Boxed passages may be improvised by repeating gestures and/or inventing new ones. Reproducing the notes exactly as written is discouraged. NB: An extremely fast speed should be prioritized above integrity of pitch.

(wide vib.) *(Arise, oh Cup-bearer, rise! and bring...)*

[17] A - lā yā_____ a - yo - has sā -

mf
earthy

(...To lips that are thirsting the bowl they praise,)

[18] -ghi,_____ a - der ka - san va nā - vel - hā_____

(For it seemed that love was an easy thing,...)

[19] _____ Ke eshgh ā - sān ne - mud_____ a - val,_____

(...But my feet have fallen on difficult ways.)

va - li of - tād mosh - kel - hā_____

21

(I have prayed the wind o'er my heart to fling...) *(...The fragrance of musk in her hair that sleeps—)*

Be_ bu - ye nā - - fe'i_____ ka - kher sa - bā_____ zān_____

22

f
brazen (*sempre non vib.*)

(In the night of her hair—yet no fragrance stays...)

tor - re bog - shā - yad,_____ Ze tā - be ja - de mesh - ki - nash

[22]

(...The tears of my heart's blood my sad heart weeps.)

che____ khun_____ of - tād_____ dar

[23]

ff
outcry

del - - - - -

[23]

dim......

In the manner of a Klezmer fiddle (quasi doina)

vib. when it feels right

24 -ha.

p

[25]

mf

p cresc......

[26]

mf

p

mf

[27]

fp < *fp* < *fp* < *mf*

p

cresc......

[28]

fp < *fp* < *f*

fp <

[28]

mf *f*

[29]

p *f* *fp* *f*

[30]

fp *f*

31

ff

[31]

f

In the manner of a Kamānche
quasi non vib.

32

f *sempre*
poco flautando á la Kamānche

[33]

f

[34]

[34]

[35]

f

[36]

37

ff

[37]

38

mf

p

to Rachel Iba & Yvette Holzwarth

IV. Winter: Yalda & Hannukah

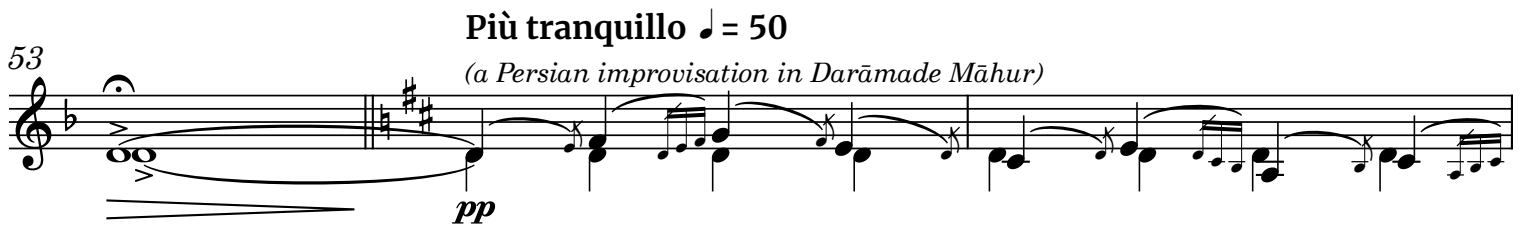
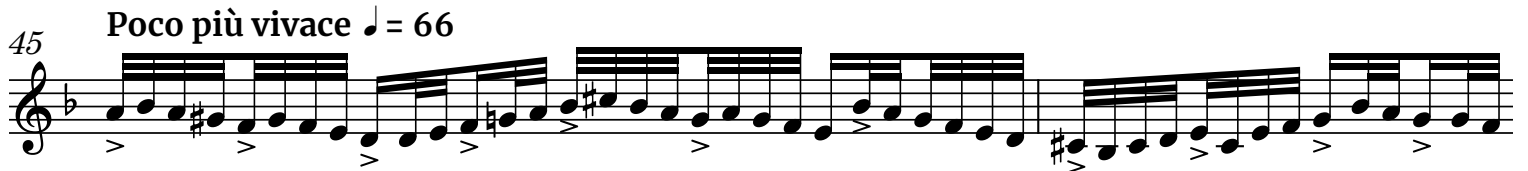
Chaconne ♩ = 56

(something between a Terkisher and a French Overture)

The musical score is written for a single melodic line on a treble clef staff in 4/4 time. It consists of 19 measures, divided into four systems. The key signature has one flat (B-flat). The score includes various dynamics and articulations:

- Measure 1:** Starts with a forte (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 4:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 7:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 10:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 13:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 16:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.
- Measure 19:** Features a piano (*p*) dynamic followed by a fortissimo (*ff*) dynamic.

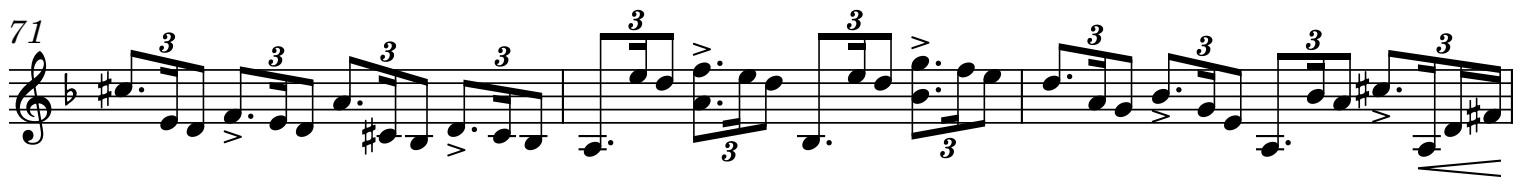
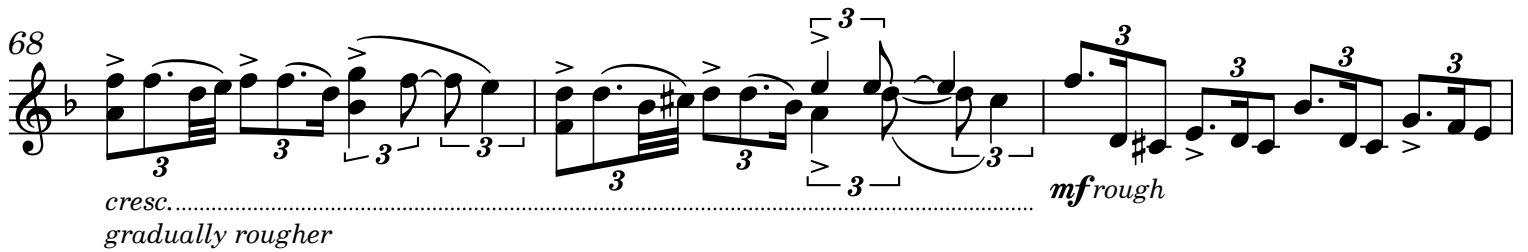
Other markings include *krekht* (marked above measures 10 and 13), *p espr.* (marked below measure 10), and *dolce cantando* (marked below measure 16). The score also includes various articulations such as slurs, ties, and accents.



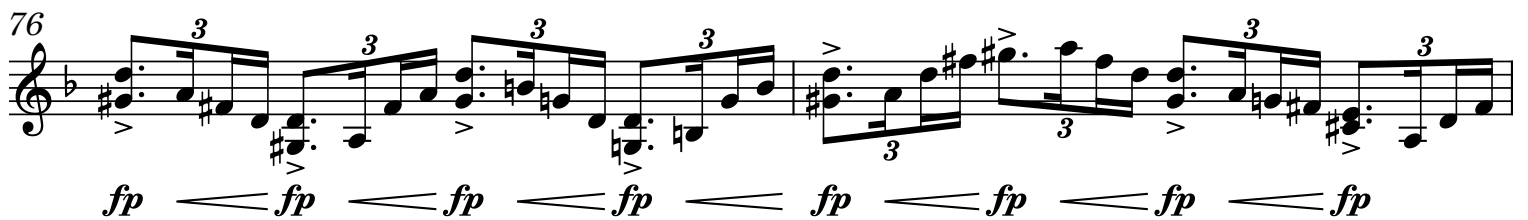


Tempo I ♩ = 56

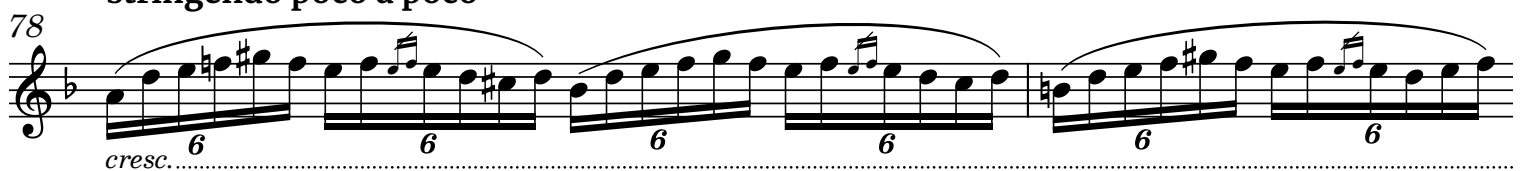
(Kereshme—traditional Persian rhythmic pattern)



(dancelike; a Hora in the Hashem Molokh mode)



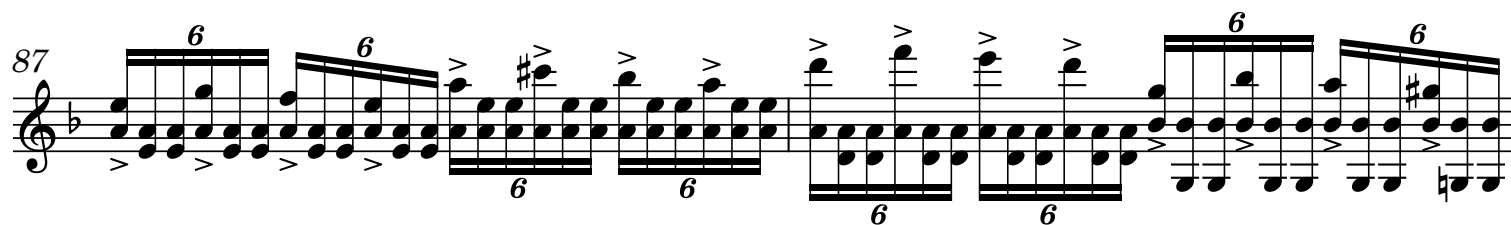
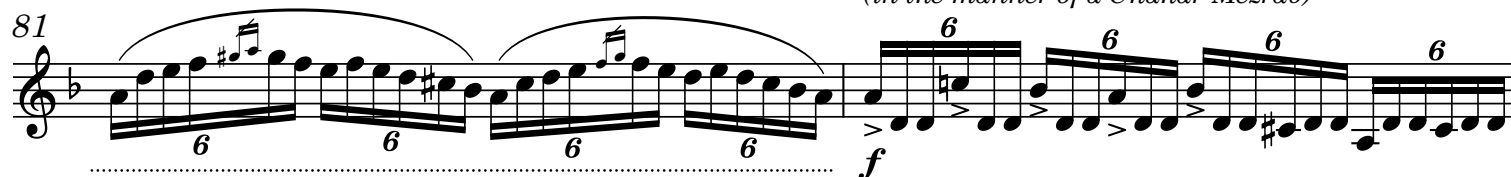
stringendo poco a poco





Vigorous, ben misurato ♩ = 69

(in the manner of a Chāhār Mezzār)



poco rit.

Tempo I subito ♩ = 56



